

Tlǎng: A Diverse, Minority-Led Vietnamese Cross-Language Knowledge Transfer Dataset

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Abstract

To be Vietnamese does not solely mean to be Kinh or Hoa, however these two ethnic groups dominate Vietnam by population and is over-represented in training datasets. Compounding the issue is the limited and often incomplete knowledge surrounding Vietnam’s fifty-three minority ethnic groups, due to limited training data and a drought of material in native languages. We introduce Tlǎng, a diverse, minority-led, Vietnamese cross-language knowledge transfer dataset that aims to spotlight ethnic minority culture, traditions, and nuances.

1 Introduction

Discussions in the field of NLP and in scholarly literature in general often conflate the idea of being "Vietnamese" with the idea of being "Kinh" or "Hoa," Vietnam’s two majority ethnic groups. (McElwee, 2004) The Kinh and the Hoa often enjoy higher wages and living standards than ethnic minority populations, and they dominate cultural discourse through spoken and written media, as well as the Internet. (Baulch et al., 2007)

This project aims to create a high-quality ethnically diverse dataset of cross-lingual knowledge transfer questions using Vietnamese, the lingua franca of all 54 ethnic groups of Vietnam. (Le Ha et al., 2014) Whilst NLP benchmarks and datasets in Vietnamese have proliferated in recent years, ethnic minority knowledge and customs have not benefited from this change, remaining under-represented in the Vietnamese NLP field, as well as the broader Vietnamese cultural discourse.

Our contributions are briefly summarized as follows:

- We present a Vietnamese cross-lingual knowledge transfer dataset, with disproportionate

attention on ethnic minority culture, modeling our dataset after ECLeKTic (Goldman et al., 2025)

- We introduce training data specifically focused on under-resourced ethnic minority culture, tapestry and daily life, many of which have never appeared in LLM corpora, transliterated into the Vietnamese language.

2 Background

2.1 NLP Efforts for Vietnamese Culture

The Vietnamese NLP community have established well-documented benchmarks for fact-based question-answering (Bui et al., 2025), natural language understanding (Nguyen et al., 2020), educational and general sentiment analysis (Hung et al., 2025) (Tran et al., 2025). However, these benchmarks largely contain easily verifiable entries from well-established sources (for instance, Wikipedia) and as such lack cultural sensitivity and uniqueness.

VietMEAgent (Nguyen et al., 2025) is a collection of images, text and metadata that conveys Vietnamese culture in a multimodal manner. However, due to the project’s reliance on pre-existing, open-source datasets to amalgamate into one large set, the dataset risks being unable to capture minority voices, which have been under-represented in previous datasets.

(Do et al., 2026) aims to bridge the gap between Vietnamese cultural knowledge and NLP corpora by introducing VIVID, a dataset comprised fully of Vietnamese idioms. Whilst idioms often capture the subtle nuances of everyday life, Vietnamese proverbs and idioms often follow the lifestyle of the Kinh ethnic group, who – due to their population – contributes the most to oral and written history.

(Toan, 2024)

3 Data Collection

3.1 Heuristics

We created 125 examples in the ECLecKTic format. Each example consists of a question-answer pair (given first in Vietnamese, then machine-translated into English) that consists of cultural knowledge specific to a small subgroup. We select question-answer pairs with low answer ambiguity, for instance, focusing on questions with numerical answers instead of descriptive answers. All prompts and solutions were entirely manually crafted and cross-checked by a team of two native Vietnamese speakers.

3.2 Topics

All prompt-and-solution pairs are culturally specific, covering a wide range of everyday scenarios but focusing specifically on ethnic minorities and their immediate context. Cultural contexts include food, ethnic history, religious rituals, festivities, family practices, and music.

3.3 Representation

The dataset was specially curated to include cultural knowledge and context from the least represented ethnic communities in Vietnam, which suffer the most from the lack of resources and culturally-specific training corpora. Table 1 (Appendix A) summarizes the distribution of all 43 ethnic groups represented in our dataset, compared to their share of the Vietnamese population.

We aim to inversely focus on the cultural experiences of ethnic groups against their population size, as such the Pu Péo, Ô Đu, Brâu, Si La and Rơ Măm ethnic groups – the five least populous ethnicities in Vietnam – have the highest concentration of entries, adjusted per 10,000 people.

3.4 Statistics

We convey the descriptive statistics of our dataset in Table 2 (Appendix B).

4 Conclusions

We have presented Tlăng, a 125-item ECLecKTic-style cross-lingual transfer-of-knowledge dataset, focusing specifically on the ethnic minority culture of Vietnam. Representing the first ECLecKTic-style dataset focusing on Vietnamese ethnic minorities, Tlăng hopes to provide a foundation for more comprehensive work surrounding the representation of Vietnamese minorities.

Future work includes expanding the dataset, covering more facets of ethnic culture, including multimodal (image, text and audio data) as well as providing entries in the native languages of ethnic groups, many of which are critically endangered.

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A Ethnic Group Distribution

Table 1 presents the detailed breakdown of ethnic group representation across our dataset relative to their population as recorded in the 2019 Vietnam National Census. ([General Statistics Office of Vietnam, 2020](#))

Ethnic Group	Count	Entries / 10k People	Population Share (%)
Chăm	8	0.4471	0.190%
Raglai	7	0.4774	0.150%
Mạ	6	1.1923	0.050%
Giẻ-Triêng	5	0.7896	0.070%
Giáy	5	0.7368	0.070%
Cơtu	5	0.6741	0.080%
Tà Ôi	5	0.9550	0.050%
Cờ Lao	4	9.9925	0.004%
Khơ Mú	4	0.4414	0.090%
Thổ	4	0.4375	0.100%
Bru-Vân Kiều	4	0.4228	0.100%
Sán Dìu	4	0.2186	0.190%
H'rê	4	0.2676	0.160%
Khmer	4	0.0303	1.370%
Mảng	3	6.4516	0.005%
Pu Páo	3	33.2226	0.001%
Si La	3	33.0033	0.001%
Lự	3	4.4398	0.010%
Pà Thẻn	3	3.6372	0.010%
Kháng	3	1.8541	0.020%
Cơho	3	0.1494	0.210%
Xơ Đăng	3	0.1413	0.220%
Hà Nhì	2	0.7831	0.030%
Mông	2	0.0144	1.450%
Ngái	2	12.1286	0.002%
Cống	2	7.3287	0.003%
Bố Y	2	6.1881	0.003%
La Hủ	2	1.6511	0.010%
Pa Dí*	2	6.1881	0.003%
Chu Ru	2	0.8605	0.020%
M'Nông	2	0.1571	0.130%
Sán Chay	2	0.0993	0.210%
Kinh**	2	0.0002	85.320%
Dao	1	0.0112	0.930%
Thái (Trắng)***	1	0.0055	1.890%
Nùng	1	0.0092	1.130%
Rơ Măm	1	15.6495	0.001%
Xiêng	1	0.0993	0.100%
Brâu	1	19.0476	0.001%
Ơ Đu	1	23.3645	0.000%
Lô Lô	1	2.0717	0.010%
La Ha	1	0.9845	0.010%
Xinh Mun	1	0.3390	0.030%

Table 1: Distribution of ethnic groups in the dataset compared to their official 2019 population figures and calculated entries per 10,000 people. *Listed under Bố Y parent ethnic group. **Majority ethnicity. ***Subgroup under the Thái ethnic group.

B Dataset Word Count Statistics

Table 2 summarizes the word count statistics of the dataset prompts and answers.

Column	Mean	Std Dev
Column A (Questions)	16.78	9.00
Column B (Answers)	2.86	1.67

Table 2: Word count summary statistics.